

Central Europe

FOUR COUNTRIES LIE at the heart of central Europe—Poland, Czechia (until 2016, the Czech Republic), Slovakia, and Hungary. The region is composed of wide plains broken by gentle hills and the Carpathian mountain range in the south. In the late 1980s, these countries broke away from decades of communist rule and, as new democracies, began to modernize. EU-members since 2004, they have seen a rise in living standards, despite the global economic crisis of 2008 hitting their growing economies.

GOLDEN PRAGUE
Prague, the capital of Czechia, is one of Europe's most charming and beautiful cities. Unlike many other central European cities, it escaped serious damage in both World Wars, and contains many fine historic buildings, soaring church spires, and grand squares.



Part of Prague's colourful history is preserved in buildings around the Old Town Square.

FAMILY FARMS

Poland has one of the largest agricultural sectors in Europe, with more than 12 percent of the workforce employed on the land. Most farms are still small, family-run businesses, growing grains, sugar beet, and potatoes. Large numbers of pigs and other animals are also kept.



TRADITIONAL TRADES

The countries of central Europe are heavily industrialized. Vast coal mines, steel works (above), and engineering works dominate the urban landscape. Although some of these sites are old and poorly equipped, these countries are trying to update machinery and introduce measures to improve standards of environmental pollution.



RELIGION
The Roman Catholic Church is very strong throughout central Europe. Attending mass on Sunday and observing religious holidays, such as Christmas and Easter, are important features of family life.

